



8 Theme: experiences

Themes · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

The theme of experiences includes sub-topics such as travel, rites of passage, childhood memories, holidays and festivals, and life transitions. Tasks on this theme often ask candidates to narrate or reflect on a specific past event, so strong responses use clear time markers, a range of past tenses, and sensory or emotional detail rather than a simple list of what happened.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Model narrative opening for an individual oral photo description: 'The photograph of the crowded train station instantly reminds me of the chaotic, exciting morning I left home for the first time to study abroad, and the theme of experiences here is about transition and independence.'

Quick check · multiple choice

Which grammatical feature is most useful when narrating a past experience?

- A Present simple tense throughout
- B A range of past tenses to sequence events
- C Only future tense forms
- D No verbs, only nouns

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Individual oral task: you are shown a photograph of a group of travellers waiting at an airport gate. Prepare a two-minute presentation connecting this image to the theme of experiences, drawing on a personal travel or transition memory, then answer follow-up questions about how travel changes people. [30]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [30]

A strong spoken response includes:

- A brief link between the image and the theme of experiences, such as travel, transition or uncertainty
- A specific personal anecdote with sensory or emotional detail, not a vague generalization
- Varied past tenses to sequence the memory clearly
- Reflection on what the experience taught the speaker or how it changed their perspective
- Genuine, extended answers in the follow-up discussion, engaging with the examiner's questions about travel and change

Quick check answer

B. Varying past tenses allows a narrator to show sequence, background and completed actions clearly.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English B guide (2018).

Original FagusED teaching material. Not an official IB publication; the sample scenarios and language are invented and generic.